journalist who covered the 2018 poll campaign. ‘It provided a critical push for BJP to jump to 105 seats.’

Multilingual Identity: Why Karnataka Is Different from the Rest of South India

In the 2018 Karnataka state election, Congress Chief Minister Siddaramaiah likened himself to the legendary seventh-century Chalukya ruler Pulakesin II, who defeated the north Indian emperor Harsha. His attempt to create a Kannada First vs Outsider narrative clearly could not stave off a saffron surge. One of the reasons this narrative did not work was because—unlike say Tamil Nadu’s Dravidian parties or Telangana’s regional identity-based politics or Andhra Pradesh’s politics forged in the idea of Telugu pride—Karnataka has never had language-focused politics. In other south Indian states, especially Tamil Nadu, the BJP could be more easily portrayed as a Hindi-speaking party of the north, espousing a Sanskritised ‘Aryavrat’ at odds with non-Brahmanical and non-Sanskritic regional identities as symbolised by the Dravidian movement. Unlike Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Kerala or Tamil Nadu, Karnataka is ‘multilingual state, with people speaking Telugu, Marathi, Kannada, Tamil’. While Kannada is by far the most widely spoken language in the state, Urdu is the second-largest mother-tongue group. There are Telugu speakers in the Hyderabad–Karnataka region, Tamil speakers in Bengaluru, Tulu speakers in the Dakshin Karnataka region, and Konkani is spoken on the coastline.[106] Karnataka is the most multilingual state in south India, the third-most in India—in terms of people who speak more than one language—according to Census data.[107] BJP MLC Lehar Singh argues that ‘the majority of people here are bilingual. They speak Marathi/Tamil, Telugu/Marathi or some such combination. This is why there is no linguistic identity fanaticism here like in Tamil Nadu. We don’t have linguistic nationalism because Karnataka is a multilingual state and most people speak at least two languages. Language-based politics doesn’t work here and people don’t like it.’[108]